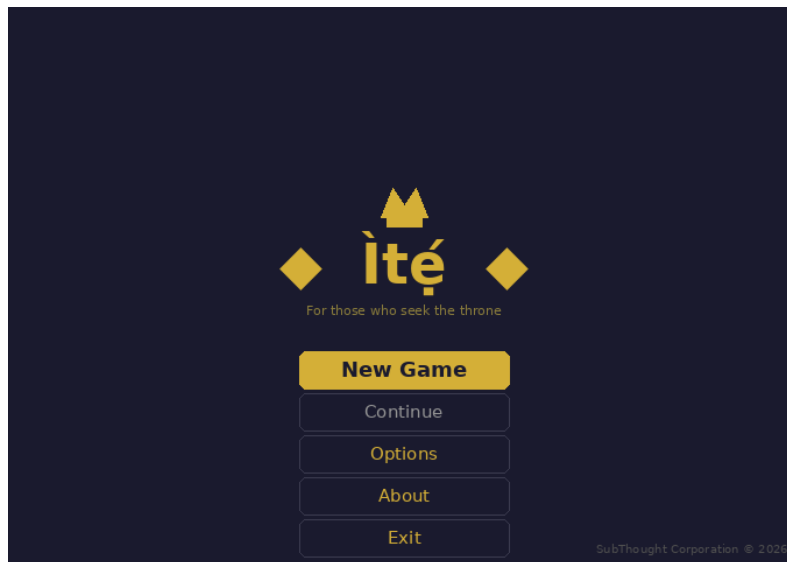




Player's Guide

For Those Who Seek the Throne

SubThought Corporation — June 2026

What Is Ìtẹ?

Ìtẹ (pronounced ee-TEH, Yoruba for “throne”) is a strategy board game built on the bones of chess. You will recognize the pieces and their movements, but that is where the familiarity ends. In Ìtẹ, every piece has hit points, attack power, and a personal purse of gold called wùrà. Pieces can be captured alive, thrown in jail, ransomed back, bribed to switch sides, or simply destroyed. There is no checkmate. You win by conquering your opponent’s king—taking the throne by force, cunning, or wealth.

Game Modes

Ìtẹ supports several configurations. Choose the one that fits your group.

2-Player (Classic)

An 8×8 board labeled a–h (columns) and 1–8 (rows). No dead zones. Each player’s army starts on the two rows closest to their edge. Your army is always displayed at the bottom of your screen. The game ends when one king is captured or defeated.

3-Player

A 14×14 board labeled a–n and 1–14. The four 3×3 corners are dead zones—no piece may enter them. Three of the four edges are assigned to players at random. Each army occupies the center eight columns of its assigned edge. The last king standing wins.

4-Player

Same 14×14 board with 3×3 corner dead zones. All four edges are occupied, one army per side. Last king standing.

2v2 Teams

14×14 board. Two teams of two players each. Teammates may be placed on adjacent edges or opposite edges (configurable in setup). A team is eliminated when its last king falls. The surviving team wins.

Setting Up a Game

Before starting, configure the match using the setup screen. The minimal view shows mode, players, AI level, start position, and time controls. Click Advanced to reveal additional settings: Options toggles for Terrain, Low Ground Penalty, Fog, and Statistics; Sound selector; and an Army Colors reference.

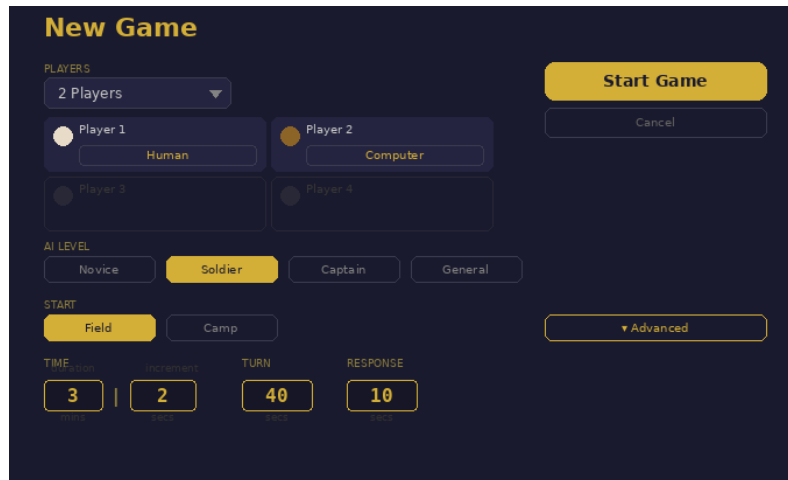


Figure 1. Game setup — minimal view

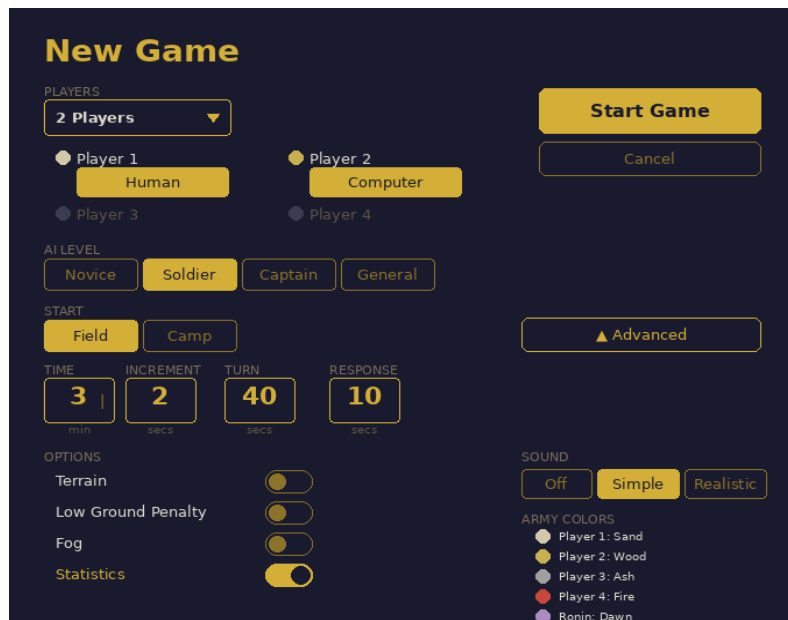


Figure 2. Game setup — advanced options revealed

Options Reference

Option	Choices	Default
Players	2 / 3 / 4 / 2v2	2
Start Position	Field (on board) or Camp (deploy manually)	Field
AI Level	Novice / Soldier / Captain / General	Soldier
Time Control	1 / 3 / 5 / 10 / 30 min + 0 / 2 / 5 / 10s increment	3 min + 2s
Turn Duration	Seconds per turn before auto-skip	40 seconds
Response Time	Seconds to respond to combat or parley	10 seconds
Terrain	Off or On (Advanced)	Off
Low Ground Penalty	Off or On — requires Terrain (Advanced)	On
Fog	Off or On (Advanced)	Off
Statistics	Off or On — show stat overlays (Advanced)	On
Sound	Off / Simple / Realistic (Advanced)	Simple
Team Position	Adjacent or Opposite (2v2 only)	Adjacent

The Board

The entire game is played from a single screen. The board sits at center, with an action panel on the right, player bars at top and bottom, and three trays (Camp, Limbo, Jail) below the board.



Figure 3. The 2-player game board — 8×8 with action panel, camp, limbo, and jail

Your army always appears at the bottom of the screen. The board is labeled a–h across the columns and 1–8 up the rows. Each piece occupies one square. Your pieces display a life bar at the bottom of the square. Enemy pieces show their graphic and nothing else—no stats.

The Pieces

Every piece has five key attributes: Wùrà (starting gold value and bounty), HP (maximum hit points), Attack (damage dealt per strike), Life (current hit points—starts equal to HP), and Quantity (how many you begin with). All pieces move exactly as they do in standard chess.

Piece Statistics

Piece	Qty	Wùrà	HP	Attack	Life	Role
Pawn	8	2	3	2	3	Expendable
Knight	2	3	4	3	4	Flanker
Bishop	2	3	4	3	4	Sniper
Rook	2	5	6	5	6	Heavy
Queen	1	15	20	9	20	Bruiser
King	1	100	10	5	10	The Throne

The king's paradox: worth 100 wùrà but only 10 HP and 5 attack. He is the most valuable target on the board and one of the most fragile. Protect him.

How Each Piece Moves

Pawn

Pawns move forward one square at a time. On their first move, they may advance two squares. Pawns cannot move backward. They attack diagonally forward—one square to the upper-left or upper-right. “Forward” is always away from the edge where your army started.

Knight

The knight moves in an L-shape: two squares in one direction (horizontal or vertical) and then one square perpendicular, or vice versa. The knight is the only piece that can jump over other pieces. It always lands on the opposite color from where it started.

Bishop

The bishop moves diagonally any number of squares. It cannot jump over pieces. A bishop starting on a light square stays on light squares for the entire game. You begin with one of each color.

Rook

The rook moves horizontally or vertically any number of squares in a straight line. It cannot jump over pieces. Rooks are powerful for controlling ranks (rows) and files (columns).

Queen

The queen combines the rook and bishop: she moves any number of squares horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. She cannot jump. With 20 HP and 9 attack, the queen is the most dangerous piece on the board.

King

The king moves one square in any direction—horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. He is slow and vulnerable but irreplaceable. If your king falls, you lose.

Pawn Promotion

When one of your pawns reaches the opponent's back rank (the farthest row from your starting edge), the PROMOTE panel activates on the action panel. You may promote the pawn into a more powerful piece by spending wùrà from the king's treasury.

Promotion Costs

Promote To	Cost (Wùrà)	Paid From
Knight	3	King's Treasury
Bishop	3	King's Treasury
Rook	5	King's Treasury
Queen	15	King's Treasury

If your king cannot afford any promotion, the PROMOTE panel stays dimmed and your pawn remains on the back rank as a pawn. Be warned: a pawn stranded on the back rank without promotion is vulnerable—an opponent can bribe it and promote it themselves using their own treasury.

The Economy: Wùrà

Wùrà (Yoruba for “gold”) is the currency of Ìtẹ. Every piece carries its own purse. The king starts with 100 wùrà as the primary war chest, called the treasury.

Earning Wùrà

You earn wùrà by defeating or capturing enemy pieces—the winner takes the loser’s entire purse. You also receive wùrà when an opponent pays ransom for one of their jailed pieces.

Spending Wùrà

Wùrà is spent on bribing enemy pieces or prisoners, paying ransoms, training pieces at camp, healing wounded pieces, gifting gold from the king’s treasury to a piece’s purse, and promoting pawns. The king’s treasury funds bribes, ransom demands, ransom offers, gifts, and promotions. A piece’s personal purse funds healing and training.

Tax and Gift

Tax moves wùrà from a piece’s purse to the king’s treasury. Gift moves wùrà from the king’s treasury to a piece’s purse. Together they let you redistribute gold across your army—funding a critical bribe from the treasury, or enriching a piece to make it harder to bribe away.

Gold management is critical. An army with superior wùrà can bribe away key defenders, ransom back veterans, train upgraded fighters, and promote pawns into queens—all without swinging a sword.

How a Turn Works

Players take turns in sequence. A round completes when every player has taken one turn. On your turn, you perform exactly one action. You have a limited time to act (default: 40 seconds). If time expires, your turn is skipped.

Available Actions

Action	Category	What It Does
Defeat	Combat	Move onto an enemy square and fight to kill. Both pieces strike simultaneously. The winner takes the loser's wùrà.
Capture	Combat	Move onto an enemy square and fight to take them alive. If you win, the enemy goes to your Jail.
Bribe	Parley	Offer wùrà to an enemy piece to switch sides. Success is probabilistic. Also works on Jail prisoners.
Demand	Parley	Set a ransom price for a piece in your Jail. The opponent must Accept or Reject.
Offer	Parley	Offer to pay ransom for one of your pieces in Limbo. The captor must Accept or Reject.
Tax	Manage	Transfer wùrà from a piece's purse to the king's treasury.
Gift	Manage	Transfer wùrà from the king's treasury to a piece's purse.
Heal	Manage	Restore life to a wounded piece using that piece's personal wùrà.
Train	Manage	Spend wùrà at Camp to permanently upgrade a piece's attack or HP.

Reactive Responses

Some actions are responses to what your opponent does to you. You have a limited window (default: 10 seconds) to respond. If time expires, defaults apply.

Response	Triggers When	What Happens
Fight	An opponent attacks your piece	Your piece fights back. Both strike simultaneously. Default if no response.
Yield	An opponent attacks your piece	Your piece surrenders. You lose the piece and its wùrà but avoid damage.
Accept	An opponent demands or offers ransom	The deal goes through. Gold and pieces change hands.
Reject	An opponent demands or offers ransom	The deal is refused. The piece stays in Jail or Limbo. Default if no response.

A response does not count as a turn.

Recuperation

At the end of each round, every piece that did not move or fight recuperates 1 life point, up to its maximum HP.

Combat

All combat takes place directly on the game board—no separate combat screen. Select one of your pieces, choose Defeat, Capture, or Bribe from the action panel, then click a valid enemy-occupied square.

Simultaneous Strikes

When you attack and the defender chooses Fight, both pieces deal their attack value as damage at the same time. If both survive, each stays on their square. If the attacker's life drops to zero, the defender wins. If the defender's life drops to zero, the attacker wins and moves onto the square. If both hit zero simultaneously, both are destroyed.

Defeat vs. Capture

Defeat destroys the loser permanently—removed from the game. You take their wùrà. Capture sends the loser to your Jail alive. From Jail, you can demand ransom or bribe them to your side.

Yielding

If the defender Yields, they surrender without combat. The attacker takes the piece and its wùrà without risk. Yield during Defeat destroys the piece. Yield during Capture sends it to Jail. Yielding is sometimes wise when a piece is badly wounded and the attacker is powerful.

Information Asymmetry

You see every stat of your own pieces: life, attack, wùrà. Enemy pieces are opaque—you see type and position, nothing else. Combat is always a calculated risk.

Camp, Limbo, and Jail

Below the board, three trays are always visible.

Camp

Your reserve bench. Pieces here are off the board but under your control. They can be deployed to the board or trained. If you use the Camp start position, all pieces begin here and must be deployed manually. Ransomed pieces and bribed prisoners return to Camp before re-entering play.

Limbo

Your pieces taken by an opponent. Their status is unknown—you don't know if they're alive in the opponent's Jail or have been destroyed. Use the Offer action to propose a ransom. If the captor accepts, you pay the agreed wùrà and your piece returns to Camp—if it is still alive. If the piece is dead, the gold is spent and nothing comes back. Offering ransom is a genuine gamble.

Jail

Enemy pieces you've captured alive. Click a jailed piece to Demand ransom or attempt to Bribe it to your side. Successfully bribed prisoners move to your Camp and fight for you—until perhaps they are bribed again. Loyalty in Ìtẹ is only as deep as the wùrà.

The Piece Lifecycle

Camp → Deploy to Board → Fight → Captured (enemy Jail / your Limbo) → Ransomed → Camp → Deploy again. Pieces can cycle through this loop multiple times.

Bribery

You can bribe any enemy piece on the board or any prisoner in your Jail. Select Bribe, click the target, enter a wùrà amount, and confirm. Success is probabilistic—the game calculates acceptance based on the target's current life, HP, personal wùrà, and how much you offered. A battered, broke piece is far more susceptible than a healthy, wealthy one.

If the bribe succeeds, the piece immediately changes to your army's color—that is the signal. Board pieces switch color in place; jailed pieces move to your Camp. The wùrà is deducted from your king's treasury. If the bribe fails, the piece does not change color and you lose nothing—but the attempt counts as your turn.

Ronin (Multiplayer Only)

When a king falls in a 3-player, 4-player, or 2v2 game, all remaining pieces of that player instantly turn Dawn purple. No popup—the color shift on the board is the only signal. These pieces are now ronin: masterless warriors with no allegiance.

Ronin remain on the board as independent fighters. They are no longer taxed by any king, so they accumulate wùrà rapidly. They can combat any player and can be bribed by anyone. Recruiting a powerful ronin through bribery can turn the tide.

In 2-player mode, the king's fall ends the game. No ronin.

Terrain (Optional Rule)

When Terrain is enabled, the board is overlaid with varied landscapes. Each square has a terrain type with a difficulty cost and an altitude level. Each terrain type is shown on the board as a color tint with a small bitmap texture: rolling lines for valleys, tiny houses for villages, waves for water, rounded bumps for hills, sharp snow-capped peaks for mountains, and bubbles with reeds for swamps. No text labels—you learn to read the terrain at a glance.



Figure 4. Board with Terrain enabled — color-coded squares

Terrain Types

Terrain	Difficulty	Altitude	Notes
Valley	1	1	Easy ground. Low cost, low position.
Village	1	1	Easy ground. Same as valley.
Water	2	0	Moderate cost, lowest altitude. Avoid if wounded.
Hills	2	2	Moderate cost but strong defensive position.
Mountain	3	3	Expensive to reach. Dominant altitude advantage.
Swamp	3	1	Expensive with no altitude payoff. A trap.

Movement Cost

Moving into a square costs its difficulty in life points. All pieces receive +10 HP when terrain is active to absorb travel wear.

Low Ground Penalty

When attacking from higher ground, your attack is increased by the altitude difference. A piece at altitude 3 attacking a piece at altitude 1 gains +2 attack. When Low Ground Penalty is enabled (the default when Terrain is on), the lower piece's attack is also reduced by the altitude difference. When Low Ground Penalty is off, only the higher piece gains a bonus—the lower piece suffers no reduction.

Fog (Optional Rule)

When Fog is enabled, you can only see squares immediately surrounding your own pieces. All other squares render in plain alternating grey—no pieces, no terrain. As your pieces advance, the fog lifts. Enemy pieces only appear on squares your pieces can attack.

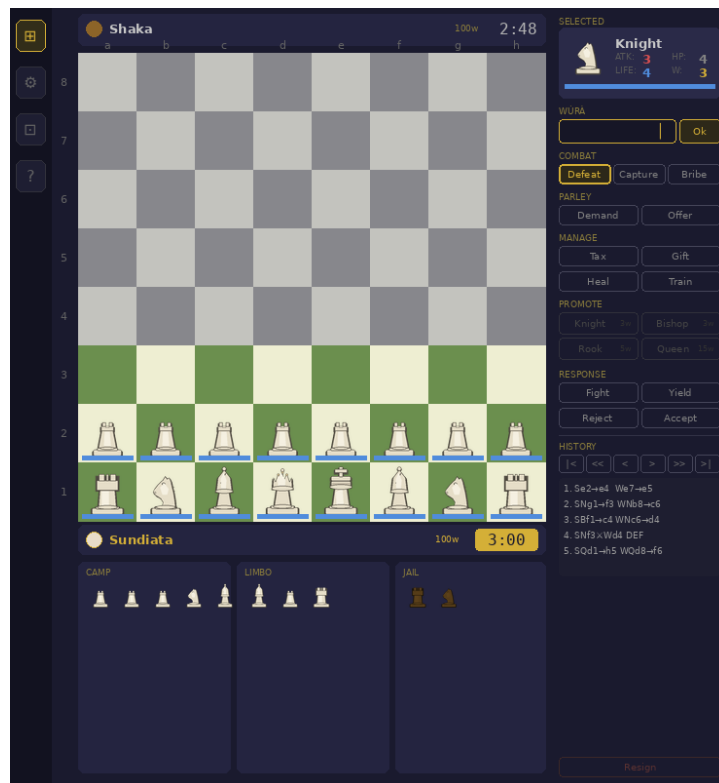


Figure 5. Board with Fog — grey squares hiding the upper board

Fog transforms the game into scouting and ambush. You must push pieces forward to see, risking them. Knights are valuable scouts because they can leap obstacles.

Reading the Board

Your Pieces

Your pieces display a life bar at the bottom of their square. The bar fills proportionally to the piece's remaining life divided by its HP—a full bar means full health, a half bar means half life remaining. There is no text label on the bar. Bar color shifts with health: blue above 50%, purple below 50%, red below 25%. Click any piece to see its full stats in the SELECTED panel.

Enemy Pieces

Enemy pieces show their graphic and nothing else. No life bar, no numbers. You know the type and position. Everything else is hidden.

Selection and Movement

Click your piece to select it—a gold border appears and gold dots mark valid destinations. Click a dot to move. Click an enemy-occupied dot to initiate combat. The opponent's last move is highlighted with gold-shaded source and destination squares.

The Interface

Action Panel (Right Side)

The action panel is organized into sections from top to bottom: SELECTED (stats of the clicked piece), WÚRÀ (editable amount field for bribes, ransoms, taxes, and gifts), COMBAT (Defeat, Capture, Bribe), PARLEY (Demand, Offer), MANAGE (Tax, Gift, Heal, Train), PROMOTE (Knight, Bishop, Rook, Queen—activates when a pawn reaches the back rank), RESPONSE (Fight, Yield, Reject, Accept—lights up when an opponent acts against you), and HISTORY (scrollable move log with playback controls). A Resign button sits below History.

Navigation Sidebar (Left Side)

A slim icon bar on the far left provides access to New Game, Settings, Board view, and Help.

Player Bars

Top and bottom bars show each player's name, army color (Sand, Fire, Ash, or Wood), wúra treasury total, and clock timer. The active player's bar is gold-accented.

Multiplayer Board (14×14)

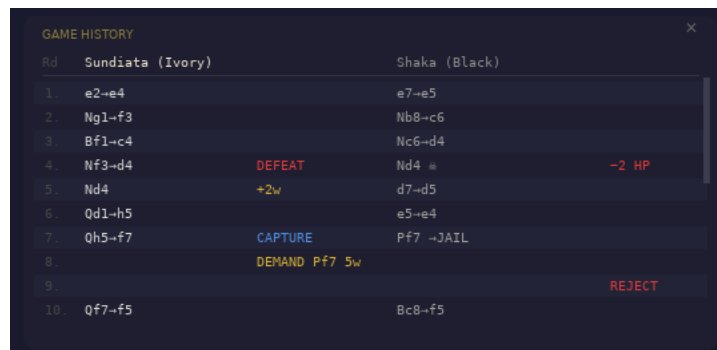
The 3-player and 4-player boards use a 14×14 grid labeled a–n and 1–14. Each corner has a 3×3 dead zone that no piece may enter. Each army occupies the center eight columns of its assigned edge. Four player bars split across the top and bottom. Four player bars split across the top and bottom.



Figure 6. The 4-player board — 14×14, corner dead zones, four armies

Game History

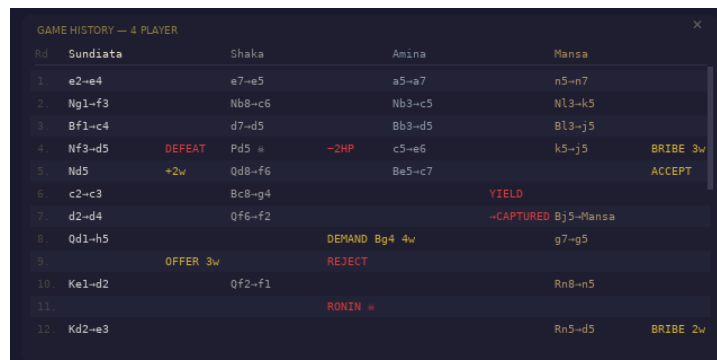
The history log records every action: round numbers, piece symbols, move notation, and combat annotations (DEF for defeat, CAP for capture, BRIBE with amount, wùrà transfers, HP loss, jail transfers). Playback controls let you step through the game move by move.



Rd	Sundiata (Ivory)	Shaka (Black)
1.	e2→e4	e7→e5
2.	Ng1→f3	Nb8→c6
3.	Bf1→c4	Nc6→d4
4.	Nf3→d4	Nd4 =
5.	Nd4	d7→d5
6.	Qd1→h5	e5→e4
7.	Qh5→f7	Pf7 →JAIL
8.		
9.		
10.	Qf7→f5	Bc8→f5

Combat annotations: DEF (row 4), +2w (row 5), CAPTURE (row 7), DEMAND Pf7 5w (row 8), REJECT (row 9).

Figure 7a. 2-player game history



Rd	Sundiata	Shaka	Amina	Mansa
1.	e2→e4	e7→e5	a5→a7	n5→n7
2.	Ng1→f3	Nb8→c6	Nb3→c5	Nl3→k5
3.	Bf1→c4	d7→d5	Bb3→d5	Bl3→j5
4.	Nf3→d5	Pd5 =	c5→e6	k5→j5
5.	Nd5	Qd8→f6	Be5→c7	
6.	c2→c3	Bc8→g4		
7.	d2→d4	Qf6→f2		
8.	Qd1→h5			
9.				
10.	Ke1→d2	Qf2→f1		
11.				
12.	Kd2→e3			

Combat annotations: DEF (row 4), +2w (row 5), -2HP (row 4), BRIBE 3w (row 4), ACCEPT (row 5), YIELD (row 6), -CAPTURED Bj5→Mansa (row 7), DEMAND Bg4 4w (row 8), OFFER 3w (row 9), REJECT (row 9), RONIN = (row 11), BRIBE 2w (row 12).

Figure 7b. 4-player game history — tracking ronin events, cross-player bribes

Winning the Game

There is no checkmate in Ìtẹ. Victory is achieved by destroying or capturing the enemy king. In 2-player, the game ends immediately. In multiplayer, the last king (or last team with a king) standing wins. You can also resign at any time.

Every path to the throne is valid: overwhelm with force, drain with economics, or corrupt with gold. The game rewards tactical combat, strategic economy, and ruthless diplomacy in equal measure.

Computer Opponents

Level	Name	Behavior
1	Novice	Random valid moves. Good for learning the interface.
2	Soldier	Basic tactics. Prioritizes defending the king.
3	Captain	Positional play, terrain use, and economic management.
4	General	Full strategy: bribes, ransoms, upgrades, and low ground exploitation.

Army Colors

Each player commands an army identified by color: Sand, Wood, Ash, or Fire. In multiplayer, a fifth color appears: Dawn (purple), marking ronin—the kingless pieces left behind when a player's king falls.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Ìtẹ	Throne (Yoruba). The name of the game.
Wùrà	Gold (Yoruba). The in-game currency carried by every piece.
Ronin	Masterless pieces after a king falls in multiplayer. Dawn (purple) color.
Camp	Your off-board reserve. Deploy or train pieces here.
Limbo	Your pieces taken by an opponent. Status unknown. Offer ransom to find out if they survived.
Jail	Enemy pieces you've captured alive. Demand ransom or Bribe to turn them.
Deploy	Move a piece from Camp onto the board.
Train	Spend wùrà at Camp to permanently increase attack or HP.
Promote	Upgrade a pawn that reaches the back rank into Knight, Bishop, Rook, or Queen.
Tax	Transfer wùrà from a piece's purse to the king's treasury.
Gift	Transfer wùrà from the king's treasury to a piece's purse.
Defeat	Attack to destroy. The loser is permanently removed.
Capture	Attack to imprison. The loser goes to the winner's Jail.
Bribe	Offer wùrà to turn an enemy piece or prisoner to your side.
Ransom	Negotiate the return of a jailed piece for wùrà.
Yield	Surrender during combat without fighting.
Fight	Counter-attack when engaged by an opponent.
Fog	Optional rule. Grey squares hiding unseen areas of the board.
Low Ground Penalty	Optional rule (with Terrain). Lower piece's attack is reduced by altitude difference.
Dead Zone	Impassable 3×3 corners on the 14×14 multiplayer board.
Recuperation	Passive healing: +1 life per round for pieces that didn't move or fight.

Ìtẹ — For those who seek the throne.